
3.5 Unit 3, Option C: The United States: Challenged and Transformed

Focus

This option concentrates on how and why conflicts and crises emerged and were resolved in the United States in the 19th and early 20th centuries. The emphasis is upon the extent to which the Union was threatened either by conflicts over civil rights and slavery, or by the differential impact of economic growth, opportunities and slump. Students study a range of factors associated with the emergence and the outcome of such conflicts and crises. They also address, and are invited to pass reasoned judgement upon, issues which have provoked disagreement and controversy among historians. A key element of study within Option C1 relates to the evaluation of interpretations related to the origins and resolution of conflict between the northern and southern states in the 1850s and 1860s. A key element of study within Option C2 relates to the causes of economic depression in the early 1930s and the impact of the New Deal.

Clarification of content for each topic can be found in *Appendix 1*.

Students entered for Option C are required to study ONE topic: C1 or C2.

C1 The United States, 1820-77: A Disunited Nation?

- Slavery and states' rights from the Missouri Compromise to Dred Scott.
- The economy of the United States: comparisons and contrasts across the Union.
- Party divisions and political conflicts in the USA, 1820-50; the Presidency of Andrew Jackson, 1829-1837.
- The Reconstruction era, 1865-77: the Black Codes from 1865 and the presidencies of Andrew Johnson and Ulysses Grant.

Associated controversies

- a) Why did civil war break out in the United States?
- b) Why did the north defeat the south in the Civil War?

C2 The United States, 1917-54: Boom, Bust and Recovery

- The economy of the United States in the 1920s.
- Political and social tensions, 1917-33: the Ku Klux Klan; Prohibition and organised crime; immigration policy; the Red Scare.
- Opposition to Roosevelt as President, 1933-45.
- The USA, 1941-54: the impact of war and the significance of anti-communism.

Associated controversies

- a) Why did the United States suffer such a serious depression in the years 1929-33?
- b) How successful was the impact of the New Deal to 1941?